

Psalms 73

Envious of the Wicked

My feet were almost gone... until I went into the sanctuary of God
KJV · Standalone study handout

1 · THE WORD (KJV)

- 1 Truly God is good to Israel, even to such as are of a clean heart.
- 2 But as for me, my feet were almost gone; my steps had well nigh slipped.
- 3 For I was envious at the foolish, when I saw the prosperity of the wicked.
- 4 For there are no bands in their death: but their strength is firm.
- 5 They are not in trouble as other men; neither are they plagued like other men.
- 6 Therefore pride compasseth them about as a chain; violence covereth them as a garment.
- 7 Their eyes stand out with fatness: they have more than heart could wish.
- 8 They are corrupt, and speak wickedly concerning oppression: they speak loftily.
- 9 They set their mouth against the heavens, and their tongue walketh through the earth.
- 10 Therefore his people return hither: and waters of a full cup are wrung out to them.
- 11 And they say, How doth God know? and is there knowledge in the most High?
- 12 Behold, these are the ungodly, who prosper in the world; they increase in riches.
- 13 Verily I have cleansed my heart in vain, and washed my hands in innocence.
- 14 For all the day long have I been plagued, and chastened every morning.
- 15 If I say, I will speak thus; behold, I should offend against the generation of thy children.
- 16 When I thought to know this, it was too painful for me;
- 17 Until I went into the sanctuary of God; then understood I their end.
- 18 Surely thou didst set them in slippery places: thou castedst them down into destruction.
- 19 How are they brought into desolation, as in a moment! they are utterly consumed with terrors.
- 20 As a dream when one awaketh; so, O Lord, when thou awakest, thou shalt despise their image.
- 21 Thus my heart was grieved, and I was pricked in my reins.
- 22 So foolish was I, and ignorant: I was as a beast before thee.
- 23 Nevertheless I am continually with thee: thou hast holden me by my right hand.
- 24 Thou shalt guide me with thy counsel, and afterward receive me to glory.
- 25 Whom have I in heaven but thee? and there is none upon earth that I desire beside thee.
- 26 My flesh and my heart faileth: but God is the strength of my heart, and my portion for ever.
- 27 For, lo, they that are far from thee shall perish: thou hast destroyed all them that go a whoring from thee.
- 28 But it is good for me to draw near to God: I have put my trust in the Lord GOD, that I may declare all thy works.

2 · CONTEXT

Asaph opens Book III of the Psalter with one of Scripture's most honest wrestling matches: why do the wicked prosper while the faithful suffer? Rather than suppress the question, he walks through it in real time—near collapse, then recovery through worship. Henry treats this as a case study in sanctified doubt; MacArthur-style commentary highlights the sanctuary, not argument alone, as the turning point where perspective is restored.

3 · VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.

Verse 1-3

The psalm opens with a confession of faith—God is good to Israel, to the pure in heart—immediately followed by confession of near-failure: his feet had almost slipped because he envied the prosperity of the wicked. Faith and doubt are held in the same breath, honestly.

Verse 4-9

The wicked are described as thriving without visible consequence: no pangs at death, bodies fat and strong, pride worn like a chain, hearts overflowing with schemes, mouths that mock heaven itself and get away with it. The injustice is described in vivid,

almost jealous detail.

Verse 10-14

Others take note and follow their example, asking cynically how God could possibly know or care. Meanwhile the psalmist's own experience is the opposite: plagued, chastened every morning, seemingly for nothing—the classic complaint that righteousness pays worse than wickedness.

Verse 15-17

He almost spoke this bitterness publicly but held back, sensing how it would wound others' faith—until he entered the sanctuary of God. There, and only there, did he understand the wicked's actual end. Worship reframes what argument alone could not resolve.

Verse 18-20

In the light of the sanctuary, the wicked are seen standing on slippery ground, suddenly destroyed, swept away like a dream that vanishes the instant one wakes. Their prosperity was never as solid as it appeared from outside.

Verse 21-24

The psalmist admits his own heart had been grieved and his thinking, in that state, as senseless as an animal's. Yet even then he had never actually been let go: God held him by the right hand, guided him by counsel, and would afterward receive him to glory. Nearness to God, not resolved circumstances, is what steadied him.

Verse 25-28

The psalm closes with one of Scripture's clearest confessions of exclusive devotion: whom have I in heaven but you, and there is nothing on earth I desire besides you. Flesh and heart will fail, but God is the strength and portion forever; those who wander from Him perish, while nearness to God is, simply, good.

4 · MEANING & APPLICATION

Meaning.

Envy of the wicked's apparent success is a real and dangerous temptation for the faithful, and Scripture does not shame the impulse to question it—it walks through the question honestly. The resolution is not a tidy explanation of why bad things happen to good people, but a relocated center of gravity: nearness to God, not a comparison of outcomes, is the actual measure of a good life.

Application for life today.

When you catch yourself envying people who seem to prosper without conscience, name it as Asaph does rather than suppress it—bring the complaint to God directly. Notice that his turning point was worship, not winning an argument; consider whether you need to step back into the presence of God rather than keep debating the unfairness in your own head. Let verse 25–26 become a personal creed: God as portion is enough, regardless of how the comparison currently looks.

5 · REFLECT & RESPOND

Write your answers in the space below. There are no “right length” answers—honesty before God is the aim.

1. Where in your life are you currently tempted to envy those who seem to prosper without integrity, as in verses 3–12?

2. What would it look like this week to bring that complaint 'into the sanctuary' rather than only rehearsing it privately?

3. How does declaring 'God is the strength of my heart and my portion forever' (v. 26) reorient your definition of a successful life?

Name: _____ Date: _____ Group / Church: _____

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, *Commentary on the Whole Bible* (themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with MacArthur Study Bible tradition (paraphrased, not quoted). Scripture: King James Version (public domain).